

KOBANE

13 Nov 2014

Kobani: The Legend

By Dr. Rashid Karadaghi

Not many people outside Rojava (Syrian-occupied Kurdistan), except for Kurds, had heard of Kobani two months ago. Today, anyone who can see, read, or hear knows something about Kobani -- and what they know honors the women and men of the legendary city, the heroic defenders of freedom on behalf of us all. Kobani makes every Kurd proud of being a Kurd. It makes all freedom-loving people proud. In a little over seven weeks Kobani has become a myth and its heroic resistance fighters -- young girls, women, and men -- have become heroes to us all. Like other cities that have fought bravely against invaders in the past, Kobani is etched in our hearts and our memory forever.

I must admit that I have been moved to tears many times these past few weeks, tears of both sorrow and pride -- sorrow for the precious young lives lost in defending Kobani against a horde of barbarians devoid of every value we hold dear in life, and pride in what the valiant Kobani women and men resistance fighters have been able to do to prevent the fall of the city to terror.

Language despairs of doing justice to the bravery, the nobility, and humanity of the resistance fighters of Rojava as well as the Peshmergas in South Kurdistan (some now also in Kobani) for resisting terror and putting their people and their homeland ahead of themselves. Language also despairs of capturing the brutality, the cruelty, and inhumanity of the enemy they are fighting, this barbaric group known as ISIL / ISIS.

The story of the people defending Kobani and other parts of Kurdistan against terror is the story of those who are fighting for something bigger than themselves. "We are tied to our land and our principles more than our lives. ... We are looking after our nation," says a female commander of the Kurdish resistance to Richard Engel of NBC News. While the rest of us worry about our little lives and never-ending worries, they worry about the survival of their people, the Kurdish people, against this onslaught of evil descending upon them for no fault of their own. In doing this, all of them face death every minute of every day and night and many of them don't make it to see the joy of victory, which is certain to come, over this army of killers. For this, we owe them a debt we can never pay back to them or their loved ones. And let us always remember that they do this voluntarily because of their love of their people and their homeland.

The people of Kobani did not attack anyone; they were attacked. Their story is the story of the Kurds -- past and present. This much-wronged people have never been the aggressor at any time in their history. They have not wanted to dominate others; others

have wanted to dominate them, mostly because of the richness of their land. The wars they have fought have always been defensive ones against aggressors just as the one they are fighting today. No one can dispute this fact no matter how far they go back in history.

Kurdish women get a lot of the credit for defending Kobani. It is well-known that about one-third of the resistance fighters in Kobani and the rest of Rojava are young women, something unheard of in the history of warfare. Their determination and bravery make us all proud. "We will liberate the town house by house. We are determined to crush terrorism and extremism," says Narin Afrin, Kobani's Kurdish female commander. "We'd rather blow ourselves up than be captured by ISIS," said Nineteen-year-old Ceylan Ozlap, who spent her last bullet taking her own life in preference to falling in the hands of the barbarians and being defiled by them. Arin Mirkan, another resistance fighter, a mother of two, blew herself up using a grenade killing many terrorists, to avoid capture by ISIS.

The sacrifices of these brave young women and their male comrades must not have been for nothing. The human and national rights of the Kurdish people everywhere in their occupied homeland must be recognized. The recognition by the US and the international Coalition of the Kurds in Rojava as an ally against ISIL / ISIS must be followed by US recognition of them as a people with national rights and aspirations. A delisting of all Kurdish resistance organizations throughout Kurdistan from the terrorist list by the US and EU is in overdue; they should never have been on such a list to begin with because they are not terrorists but fighting terrorism; they are patriotic groups fighting for the Kurdish people's basic rights. The people of Kobani and the rest of Rojava must not be abandoned once their usefulness to the mission runs out. They deserve US and international support in achieving their freedom.

Whether Kobani makes it or not (I hope it does), whether it remains free or falls into evil's hands matters little now, for Kobani and its defenders have entered history and will be honored forever. Kobani put Rojava (and Greater Kurdistan) on the map. It put the Kurdish struggle for freedom from oppression and domination by the occupiers of Kurdistan in the consciousness of the world. It obliterated the artificial and imposed-by-force borders between the four parts of occupied Kurdistan, borders that were designed to divide the Kurds and keep them under occupation. Never before has there been such co-operation and co-ordination among the resistance forces of all parts of Kurdistan.

The Kurds in Syria will never again accept oppression and occupation by any Syrian regime -- they never had. They want to rule themselves by themselves democratically. Kobani makes us all proud. It has shown us all that the human spirit is impossible to crush when fighting for a just cause, regardless of the superior power of the enemy. In the words of Narin Afrin, the female commander of the Kurdish resistant fighters defending the besieged city, "Kobani has a bigger message than defeating ISIS; it is a human being's belief in himself and his will power."

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AFP
15 Nov 2014

ISLAMIC STATE FACES WAR OF ATTRITION IN SYRIA'S KOBANE

The Islamic State group is locked in a war of attrition in the Syrian border town of Kobane, where Kurdish fighters backed by US-led air strikes are mounting fierce resistance.

Two months after IS launched a major offensive to try to capture the strategic prize on the Turkish frontier, the jihadists have failed to defeat the town's Kurdish defenders.

"Several weeks ago, it looked like Kobane would fall, but it is now clear that it will not," said Romain Caillet, a French expert on jihadist movements.

"IS controls more than half of the town but is unable to advance further," he told AFP.

Buoyed by a string of victories in Syria and Iraq, IS launched a major offensive on September 16 to seize Kobane and expand its self-proclaimed Islamic "caliphate".

The jihadists believed they would quickly conquer the small town in northern Syria, which was little known to the outside world before the deadly fighting broke out.

Even the United States and Turkey warned in October that the town was teetering on the brink.

IS took over dozens of villages surrounding Kobane, known in Arabic as Ain al-Arab, besieging the town's Kurdish fighters.

On October 6, the jihadists reached the gates of Kobane, triggering panic among civilians.

Tens of thousands fled across the border into Turkey in fear of the reputed brutality of the IS fighters.

The jihadists, equipped with advanced weaponry seized from Iraqi and Syrian troops, then fought their way into central Kobane.

But their advance has since faltered in the face of fierce Kurdish resistance and US-led bombings on IS targets.

According to the Syrian Observatory for Human Rights, more than 600 jihadists and nearly 370 Kurdish fighters have died in the battle for Kobane.

The fighting also killed around 24 civilians in Kobane, which used to be home to around 150,000 people, most of them Kurds.

IS "now faces a war of attrition that is costing it more than its Kurdish adversaries", said Rami Abdel Rahman, director of the Britain-based Observatory.

Kurdish forces on Wednesday cut off a key supply route used by the jihadists, according to the Observatory, which monitors the war in Syria through a network of local sources.

- 'A trap' -

Kobane has become a major symbol of resistance against IS, which has committed widespread atrocities and imposed its harsh interpretation of sharia law.

The town's capture would be a major prize for the jihadists, giving them unbroken control of a long stretch of Syria's border with Turkey.

But after IS seized dozens of Kurdish villages and broke the defences of Kobane in mid-October, "then it fell into a terrible trap," said Caillet.

Initially the United States said it did not consider Kobane to be strategic, but then "US warplanes went into action" launching strike after strike against IS positions, he said.

Every time IS seized a building, positioning dozens of fighters inside, the US-led coalition warplanes would bombard them, killing a large number of militants.

Caillet said that foreigners, including French, Uzbek and Chechen jihadists, have been battling alongside Syrian combatants.

"There were even five French (jihadists) killed in a single strike," he said.

- 'Urban warfare' -

Abdel Rahman said the two sides had remained deadlocked, even since about 150 heavily armed Iraqi peshmerga forces entered Kobane at the end of October to reinforce their Syrian Kurdish comrades.

Kobane has become the scene of "urban warfare in a town divided into two," he said.

Snipers are playing a key role, with jihadists positioned on rooftops in areas under their control and on the battle frontlines, said Abdel Rahman.

He also doubts the town will fall to IS thanks to the "high morale" of the town's Syrian Kurdish defenders and their peshmerga reinforcements.

IS still controls vast areas around the town, but has deployed most of its fighters to the frontlines, leaving its positions vulnerable to attack.

"This is making the group increasingly nervous," said Abdel Rahman.

The fierce fightback has even sparked hopes among Kurds that IS could be driven out of the town.

"We are witnessing the defeat" of IS in Kobane, said Farhad Shami, a Kurdish journalist inside the battleground town.

AFP

11 Nov 2014

Syria Kurds 'recapture' areas of Kobane from IS

Kurds battling the Islamic State jihadist group in Kobane reportedly made advances Tuesday in the south of the flashpoint Syrian town on the border with Turkey.

Top Kurdish officials told AFP their fighters were advancing "street by street", voicing confidence that the IS would soon be ejected.

The Syrian Observatory for Human Rights backed up the report.

"The (Kurdish) People's Protection Units (YPG) recaptured streets and buildings in the south of Kobane, after a fierce battle against the IS that began yesterday (Monday) evening," said the Britain-based Observatory.

The monitor also said the YPG and its Iraqi peshmerga backers shelled IS positions on Tuesday elsewhere in Kobane, which is known in Arabic as Ain al-Arab.

On Monday night, the US-led coalition that launched air strikes in Syria in September hit IS positions in Kobane's southeast.

Kobane has been under IS siege since mid-September.

Syria's Kurds are being backed by Iraqi peshmerga fighters and Syrian rebels in their bid to reclaim the town from jihadist hands.

More than 1,000 people have been killed in the fighting for Kobane, most of them jihadists.

Syrian Kurdish chief Saleh Muslim said the YPG were advancing "street by street" and that they would "recapture the town in a very short time".

And the Kurds' top field commander in Kobane, Narin Afrin, a 40-year-old woman, said by telephone: "We have been resisting for 56 days in very difficult conditions."

Kobane has become a symbol of resistance against jihadists who control swathes of territory in Syria and Iraq, committing brutal abuses against rivals and the local population.

The Huffington Post
14 Nov 2014

Kobane: Hunger Strikes and Air Strikes

By John Feffer, Director, Foreign Policy in Focus

Moustafa Mohamad has been consuming nothing but Gatorade for more than two weeks as he stands at the traffic overpass at Dupont Circle and tries to get the attention of

passersby, the news media, and the Washington powerbrokers. He is fasting for Kobane, the Syrian Kurdish town near the Turkish border. Kurdish fighters and Free Syrian Army rebels are currently locked in a fight with the Islamic State over the fate of the town and the region.

It's not an easy sell. Washington is certainly one of the most news-savvy cities in the country, but many pedestrians have no idea where Kobane is. They stare at the mannequin dressed in a red robe with the sign next to it, "ISIS Slave Sale: \$500 for Kurdish Women." Someone who obviously didn't bother to read the many placards on display called the police to complain about a pro-ISIS demonstrator at Dupont Circle.

True, the allegiance of the factions fighting in Syria can be difficult to follow. Even the Obama administration has had a hard time deciding which groups to support and which ones to put on the terrorism list. But Kobane is more than just another town in the civil war in that benighted country. It is fast becoming a symbol of stubborn resistance to ISIS and its brutal policies.

If Kobane falls, it will not likely just be a territorial acquisition. The Kurds expect a scourge much like what has already befallen the Yazidis at the hands of ISIS: All men over the age of 10 killed and the women sold into slavery. UN special envoy Staffan de Mistura has compared the situation to Srebrenica -- the town in Bosnia where Serbian paramilitaries slaughtered thousands of Muslim civilians -- and has called on the international community to save Kobane.

Moustafa Mohamad decided he had to do something. Back in the early 1990s, Mohamad represented Kobane in the Syrian parliament. After becoming disillusioned with the possibilities of change, he went into exile in the United States. He has lived for 10 years in the Denver area.

When his hometown became the latest target of the Islamic State, Mohamad came to Washington to plead his case. He linked up with another exile, Kani Xulam, the director of the American Kurdish Information Network, who has been helping with logistics and also pressing for congressional support on Capitol Hill.

Their main ask is for a humanitarian corridor between Turkey and Kobane to save the civilians remaining in the town. Although press reports indicate a remaining civilian population only in the hundreds, Kani Xulam estimates that there are around 2,000 people who have remained to help the Syrian Kurdish fighters in the People's Protection Units (YPG) that are defending the city.

The other two demands are more controversial. The first is that the United States should increase its support for the YPG. In mid-October, in addition to launching air strikes against Islamic State targets around Kobane, the administration began to drop arms and aid for the Kurdish fighters. Particularly with Samantha Powers at the UN, the administration is sensitive to anything resembling genocide happening on its watch. It doesn't want Kobane to cast a shadow over the Obama years in the way that Srebrenica or Kigali did for the Clinton era.

Advocates are also calling on Turkey to allow Kurds to cross the border to fight against

the Islamic State. The most that Turkey has done is allow the Iraqi Kurdish peshmerga to crossthrough Turkey to fight the Islamic State. But the Turkish government has been reluctant to allow its own Kurds to help the YPG in the belief that it works hand in hand with the Kurdish separatist movement PKK in Turkey. Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan even went so far as to say, "To us, ISIS is the same as PKK." Indeed, some reports suggest that Turkey might even support ISIS against the Kurds. More likely, Turkey is willing to adjust its strategy depending on how best to achieve its ultimate goal: dislodging Syrian leader Bashar al-Assad.

The Obama administration has just announced that it will send another 1,500 troops to Iraq to train Iraqis and Kurds. The United States is also planning to bring Syrian fighters to Saudi Arabia for training. But the United States also doesn't want to strain relations with Turkey, a key ally. And it is fully aware of how wary the American public is of getting involved in yet another war in the region. So the Obama administration is desperate to find a balance: air strikes but no (or few) boots on the ground, attacks on ISIS but no inadvertent bolstering of the Assad regime, assembling a coalition of Arab states against ISIS but trying to prevent some of these states from funding extremist factions on the ground, and so on.

Meanwhile, Moustafa Mohamad has just wrapped up his vigil at Dupont Circle. The tide seems to be turning against ISIS in and around Kobane. If Kurdish fighters are successful, he will go back to visit his home town. After all, he still has family there. For him the conflict is deeply personal, so personal in fact that he has just recently changed his name. He now wants to be referred to as Azad Kobani, or Free Kobane.

Rudaw
12 Nov 2014

Fighting rages in southern Kobane

By Alexander Whitcomb

ERBIL- Joint Syrian and Iraqi Kurdish forces are making steady progress in breaking the Islamic State's nearly two month long siege of Syrian border town Kobane, according to Peshmerga officers.

On Tuesday US-led coalition airstrikes hit targets south and east of the city - including sites along the road to Aleppo - in response to ISIS artillery shelling.

This followed a night of intense fighting between Syrian Kurdish People's Protection Units (YPG) and Islamic State (ISIS) forces in the south of the city, which continued until this morning, according to the UK-based Syrian Observatory for Human Rights.

The Observatory reported that YPG advanced in several areas, and that Peshmerga forces had assisted them in certain fronts south of the city. It cited sources saying that ISIS was going to launch offensives in Homs and Hama in order to boost the morale of fighters frustrated in Kobane.

Peshmerga officials told Rudaw that four fighters from the mainstream western-backed rebel Free Syrian Army had been killed in the fighting on Tuesday, and that one had been injured. Approximately 200 lightly armed Free Syrian Army forces arrived to reinforce YPG fighters in late October, followed days later by Peshmerga forces bringing heavy weapons and artillery.

Peshmerga also said the bodies of 11 ISIS militants had been discovered after a series of clashes. The

Syrian Observatory for Human Rights estimates over 1000 people have been killed in the Kobane area since the siege began in mid-September, with the majority killed from ISIS. No Peshmerga deaths have been reported thus far.

Salih Muslim, head of the political wing of the YPG, told reporters in Paris that he was confident "they would recapture the town in a very short time," and YPG fighters are in good spirits after 56 days of fighting, although he entreated western governments to provide more military support Syrian Kurds.

The Telegraph UK

12 Nov 2014

US air strikes help halt Isil advance towards Kobane

American support aids Kurdish forces defending Syrian town of Kobane as over 750 Islamic State fighters are reported to have been killed in bombings

By Richard Spencer

The Kurdish defenders of the besieged town of Kobane claim to be pushing back their Isil jihadist attackers with the help of US airstrikes and aid drops.

The militia leading the fight against Isil, the YPG, took a key supply road, according to a co-leader of the YPG's political arm, the PYD.

"A group of the YPG is now controlling the road linking the town and Halanja in southern Kobane, which was previously under the control of Isil," the leader, Asia Abdullah, told The Telegraph.

"There is some advance inside the town, especially the eastern zone."

A combination of air strikes, an arms drop to the YPG, and the arrival of reinforcements from the Iraqi Kurdish Peshmerga and some Free Syrian Army rebels, has managed to hold the rapid Isil advance.

Figures released yesterday by the Syrian Observatory for Human Rights, a monitoring group, said that US strikes had killed around 750 Isil fighters in the country, of which hundreds are known to have been involved in the fighting around Kobane.

In addition, the strikes killed 68 members of the other leading jihadist group in Syria, Jabhat al-Nusra, which is loyal to al-Qaeda, as well as 50 civilians, the Observatory said. Isil still controls half of Kobane, however. Ms Abdullah said Isil was re-mobilising on the outskirts of town, and near Jarablus, the Syrian Arab town also on the Turkish border to the west.

Meanwhile, allied air strikes including by an RAF drone may also have helped the government in neighbouring Iraq halt and perhaps reverse Isil gains there.

Baghdad claimed to have retaken most of the key town of Baiji, north of Baghdad, where

the first British drone strikes hit earlier this week. It is home to the country's largest oil refinery, which has been besieged by Isis for months but whose defenders are now hopeful of relief.

Coalition strikes on Iraq have been sporadic compared to recent US-led campaigns, such as over Libya in 2011. The US is keen not to become closely embroiled without more effective attempts by the Baghdad government to persuade Iraq's Arab Sunni population, which is Isis's base, to join forces against the jihadists.

The US is also hoping that Baghdad will reorganise the Iraqi army, which failed lamentably to hold its ground against Isis as it advanced through the country. The new prime minister, Haidar al-Abadi, sacked or retired 36 senior officers yesterday/Wednesday for corruption, which has been identified as a major factor weakening the army's resolve.

The army has also been reinforced by Iranian-backed militias, with Qassim Suleimani, leader of the Al-Quds Brigade of Iran's Revolutionary Guard and one of the country's most powerful figures, making personal appearances on the front line.

Jeremy Binnie, who monitors the war for IHS Jane's, said the pro-Iraq government forces were "more solid". "The air strikes have disrupted (Isis) command and control, and they are going to have to move and communicate in different ways," he said.

"But it's not just the US-led coalition - there's an awful lot of Iranian stuff going in in terms of weapons and assistance, and Qassim Suleimani is playing a leading role on the ground."

NBC News
11 Nov 2014

Engel in Kobani: Women Are on the Front Lines Against ISIS

BY RICHARD ENGEL

KOBANI, Syria — The tip of 26-year-old Viyan Peyman's rifle pokes through a hole in a wall on the front line of Kobani, a Syrian city that has been under ISIS attack for the last two months. Peyman is laying on a mattress, dressed in fatigues.

The room, in what until recently was a family home, is now a sniper's nest, dirty and darkened by a thick curtain.

She hides behind heavy sandbags, scanning for her next target in the street below. Her finger is always on the trigger. She fires shots sparingly to save ammunition and to hide her location.

Kobani is now a city of snipers, and, less than 200 yards away in an adjacent building, an ISIS fighter

has his weapon trained this way. "ISIS are just across the street, and when I see them, I shoot them," Peyman says.

She speaks eloquently in Kurdish with poetic flourishes.

She was a teacher before the war. "As women we need to stand shoulder to shoulder with our male comrades and fight ISIS," she says.

The Kurdish fighters here all call one another comrades. They're secular nationalists. They have no ranks. ISIS propaganda videos claim the group has captured 90 percent of Kobani. It's not true.

During four days in the city, it appeared to NBC News that the Kurdish fighters, mainly of the People's Protection Unit and the Women's Protection Unit, control about half of Kobani. ISIS controls the other half.

Between Peyman and another female fighter is a box of homemade grenades. Made of empty cans, they use nails, screws and bolts for shrapnel.

The fighters "light it and throw it out," Viyan says, gesturing to the hole in the wall. Asked why there were so many women on the front line, she proudly declared that it was in their blood.

"We stand and fight, especially here in the Middle East, where women are treated as inferiors," she says. "We stand here as symbols of strength for all the women of the region."

Peyman has already bled for her city. She was shot twice — once in the leg, a second bullet in the stomach — but she returned to her post.

Her goal, she says, is to defend both Kobani and women's rights. Inside its self-declared caliphate, ISIS has forced women to wear veils. The group has taken women as prisoners, raping and enslaving them, according to rights groups.

"I promised myself that no matter where there is a minority that is under attack, I will be there to fight for their rights. That's the pledge I made," Peyman says.

During a brief pause in the fighting, she steps into the hallway to smoke a cigarette. She sings a folk song she wrote herself.

The lyrics honor friends she's lost. Shots ring in the background as she sings. The fight for Kobani is far from over.

For ISIS, crushing these secular, pro-U.S. fighters would be a major propaganda victory. But fighters like Peyman are putting up a fight the militants appear not to have anticipated.

They are strong women and brave men standing their ground and defending their homes. For now, at least, Kobani is holding on.

TVNewser
11 Nov 2014

NBC's Richard Engel in Syria: 'The Most Dangerous, Unpredictable War I've Covered'

By Mark Joyella

TVNewser caught up with NBC's chief foreign correspondent [Richard Engel](#), who is filing a series of reports this week for NBC News programs from the Syrian town of Kobane, a symbol of the U.S.-led fight against ISIS in Syria and Iraq. "It continues to be the most dangerous, unpredictable war I've covered," Engel tells TVNewser. "In this case,

however, everyone on our team felt the risk was worth the trip because what's happening in Kobane is critical to understanding the U.S. strategy in the war on ISIS. It is also an amazing story of people standing up to a vicious enemy."

One of those people is a 26-year-old female Kurdish fighter, [Viyan Peyman](#), who is fighting to defend Kobane from ISIS. Her story is rich and human, but as with every person in Syria, there is intense risk anytime an American journalist ventures into the warzone and starts asking questions. "We felt comfortable with our contacts," said Engel. "It takes time to build those relationships. No one just should pack a bag, grab a camera and go to Syria."

After several days embedded with a group of Kurdish fighters in Kobane, Engel and his crew have safely returned to Turkey. We asked about the logistics of making such dangerous reporting trips, and how he avoids kidnapping or violence.

"You will always stand out," Engel said. "Journalists can grow beards. They can dress in local clothing and wear colorful scarves, but inevitably you will be noticed. The most important thing is having a plan to get in and out of where you are going, knowing what you want, and leaving as soon as you have it."

Engel's stories have already aired on "NBC Nightly News" and NBC's "Today." Tonight's report on "Nightly" focuses on Peyman, who is also an aspiring folk singer when she isn't fighting to defend Kobane.

Engel tells us finding stories like Peyman's come from experience, and being very, very careful. "You need to be close to understand what's going on and being on the frontlines isn't always the most dangerous place. It is far more dangerous to be careless about the company you keep and staying too long in a hostile environment."

Engel will have an hour-long special on MSNBC this Friday at 9pmET, "Richard Engel Reporting: The Battle Against ISIS."

The Conversation

11 Nov 2014

<http://theconversation.com/the-battle-for-kobane-offers-a-glimpse-of-kurds-new-model-democracy-34027>

The battle for Kobane offers a glimpse of Kurds' new model democracy

by Karthick Manoharan, PhD Student and Graduate Teaching Assistant in Politics at the University of Essex

As the battle against Islamic State fighters draws in viewers across the world, there has been some attention given to the men and women resisting them in northern Syria. The Syrian part of Kurdistan, or Rojava, as the Kurds would like to call it, has been fighting Islamists for well over two years now but only recently has the battle for the border town of Kobane brought them to light.

And while it's easy to portray the Kurdish people as pitted against this new terrorist threat, they are actually involved in something far more profound. Kobane is symbolic and the conflict there carries a universal significance. Not only are the Kurds battling the Islamists, but they are also attempting to create a model of democracy that might actually bring stability to a war-torn region.

The Kurdish political vision is not founded on any particular racial, ethnic, regional or religious belief but rather on an idea, or a set of ideas, that should resonate with people everywhere.

Fighters in Kobane claim to be standing up for the freedom of everyone in the region, be they Kurds, Turks, Arabs or anyone else. The way the fighters in Kobane have challenged stereotypical gender roles is just one example.

As far as religious difference goes, Kobane disproves both Islamophobes who believe the Middle East to be incapable of progress and politically correct Islamophiles who push the patronising idea that religious identity is a top priority for Muslims the world over. In their readiness to defend the Yazidi minority against persecution from IS, the Kurds have essentially been promoting a radical secularism and a vision of tolerance in a region torn by religious strife.

What is novel about the Kurdish struggle for self-determination is its very definition of self-determination. The concept, when applied to nations, is generally taken to mean the right of nations to secede and form states of their own, but the Kurds see it differently. Many believe an experiment in democratic confederalism is what the region really needs.

This is an idea espoused by PKK founder Abdullah Ocalan, who is a central intellectual and moral figure for Kurds. The PKK, or the Kurdistan Workers' Party, has been fighting Turkey for greater autonomy since 1978 and has also trained Kurdish fighters in Kobane. Ocalan's writing, compiled from within the confines of a Turkish prison where he has languished for about 15 years, has provided a solid ideological plank for the Kurdish struggle. He believes nation states are inherently oppressive. While oppressed groups might have a legitimate desire to form states of their own, even such newly formed states only serve to replace one form of domination with another. For him, the nation state is linked to xenophobic nationalism, sexism and religious fundamentalism.

Democratic confederalism is a system of governance that would be based on greater collective consensus and voluntary participation. Ecology and feminism are seen as central pillars for local self-governance. It calls for an economic system that should be based neither on exploiting human labour nor the unsound use of natural resources.

Kobane has essentially implemented this theory in practice. The ideas might seem utopian and realists may, quite legitimately, question the sustainability of autonomous communes that do not have the political or military backing of a centralised state. But as Oscar Wilde said, progress is the realisation of Utopia. Maybe Kobane's progress is just that.

The struggle for Kobane is an event of global significance on a par with the Declaration of Independence, the Storming of the Bastille, the Paris Commune, or the Vietnamese victory at Dien Bien Phu. Success for the Kurds would challenge established intellectual, ethical and political horizons.

At a time when right-wing parties are growing in Europe and elsewhere, and minority fundamentalism is growing in parallel, the Kurds are offering something different and it should not be ignored. In that sense, they are fighting for everyone.

The New Yorker

8 Nov 2014

What Kobani Means for Turkey's Kurds

By Jenna Krajeski

On the Kurdish new year in March, 2013, a letter was hand-delivered to political representatives of

Turkey's Kurds in the southeastern city of Diyarbakir. It had been sent from the prison on the island of Imrali where Abdullah Ocalan, the founder of the Kurdistan Workers' Party (P.K.K.), was being held. Ocalan's letter told the Kurds that their thirty-year war with the Turkish state had come to an end. At a new year's celebration held just outside the city, politicians read the document aloud as though it were a manifesto. People wept and rushed the stage.

Ocalan's announcement marked the official start of a long-anticipated peace process, which Turkey's Kurds hoped would end decades of violence and grant them the rights to language, education, and self-governance for which they had been fighting. About forty thousand people—soldiers and civilians—have died in the conflict, and Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, then the Prime Minister and now the President, saw peace with the Kurds as a cornerstone of his legacy. But the country's decision to treat the P.K.K. as a political party was a thorny one. For decades, Turkish officials had been portraying Ocalan as the leader of a terrorist organization, and, by negotiating with him, the ruling Justice and Development Party (A.K.P.) was asking for a nationwide change in attitude: if Turks wanted peace, they would have to compromise with people they'd long regarded as the country's biggest security threat. Nevertheless, for close to two years—through anti-government protests in Istanbul, a corruption scandal affecting Erdoğan, and the passing of more than a few brazenly oppressive laws—the peace process remained largely intact.

At the same time, though, across the border in Syria, a more radical Kurdish experiment was unfolding, courting Turkey's ire and exposing the limits of its commitment to negotiating with the Kurds at home. As popular uprisings against Syrian President Bashar al-Assad gradually morphed into a civil war, Syria's Kurds, who were oppressed by Assad's government but did not trust the opposition forces fighting the war, began carving out some autonomy for themselves in a northeastern strip of Syria that they refer to as Rojava. There, they established three self-governing cantons, protected by the People's Protection Unit (P.Y.G.), the Syrian affiliate of the P.K.K., and led, mostly, by the People's Democratic Party (P.Y.D.). Rojava has excited the Kurds, but it worries Turkey. "If it survives, it will be on a smaller scale what Kurds in Turkey want for themselves," Abbas Vali, a sociologist at Istanbul's Bogaziçi University who focuses on Kurdish issues, told me.

When militants from the Islamic State in Iraq and al-Sham (ISIS) surrounded the Syrian Kurdish town of Kobani, which lies inside Rojava, during the first week of October, the tensions between Turkey and the Kurds resurfaced. For weeks, Turkish tanks sat on the other side of the border, preventing Kurdish fighters and supplies from crossing into Syria. Protests erupted across the country, leading to forty deaths. But the Turkish reaction wasn't surprising; despite its commitment to peace at home and its partnership with the Kurdistan Regional Government in Iraq (an autonomous region, bordering Turkey, that Dexter Filkins wrote about for the magazine in September), the A.K.P. rejects Kurdish autonomy in Turkey and Syria. "The canton system is anathema to the Turks," Henri Barkey, a professor of international relations at Lehigh University, told me. "You can have one Kurdish autonomous region on your border, but two is a disaster, because then Turkish Kurds are going to basically say, 'Hey, what about us?'" Turkey's position was also rational with respect to the country's internal politics—a recent poll showed that Turks fear the P.K.K. at least as much as they do ISIS; a small majority thought that the Kurdish group actually posed the bigger threat.

Amid an international outcry over its inaction in Kobani, the Turkish government resorted to what has in the past been a reliable tactic: it raised the specter of the P.K.K., and began calling it (and, by extension, the Y.P.G.) terrorists. Then, on October 14th, Turkish forces hit P.K.K. targets in Hakkari, close to the border with Iraq, the first such strikes since peace talks began. "I see it as Erdoğan sending a message to the international community, reminding everybody that the P.K.K. is a terrorist group," Aliza Marcus, the Washington-based author of "Blood and Belief: The P.K.K. and the Kurdish Fight for Independence," told me. Marcus had traveled recently to Hakkari for research, and she came away believing that the P.K.K. posed no military threat. "It's Erdoğan lashing out. He's under pressure and the Kurds are gaining sympathy. ... He's angry. His style of leadership these days is taking revenge."

Marcus also observed a shift in the coverage by the international media, and by some Turkish outlets, following the airstrikes. "It's not, 'Turkey attacked the P.K.K.,' " she said. "It's 'Turkey attacked the Kurds.' " This change in perception drew on months of good press that had been showered on the Iraqi Kurds and the peshmerga fighting on the front lines against ISIS, as well as on the media's presence

along the border, where cameras had captured footage of the blockade set up by the Turkish Army and the fighting in Kobani. Kurds across Turkey, Iran, Iraq, and Syria, too, rallied around the battle. A town in Iraqi Kurdistan known for being a source of rebellion against Saddam Hussein renamed a street “Kobani.”

“Kobani today is for Syrian Kurds and Turkish Kurds what Halabja was for Iraqi Kurds,” Barkey told me, referring to the site of Hussein’s chemical-weapons attacks in 1988 against the Kurds. “It’s a stepping stone for national mobilization and nation-building. ... Even if Kobani falls, it will strengthen Kurdishness. This was a Turkish miscalculation.”

When Turkey finally relented to allow a force of about a hundred and fifty Iraqi Kurdish peshmerga to enter Kobani, Turkish Kurds were relieved. But this relief seemed to relate more to their sense of solidarity with their fellow Kurds than to any expectation that the peshmerga could win the fight—“Let’s face it, the fiercest Kurdish fighters are already there,” a friend in Erbil told me—or that Turkey’s stance on Kurdish autonomy was softening. Erdoğan had called the pressure on Turkey a “psychological war,” and he was not wrong—sending the peshmerga, who in Iraq were at odds with the P.K.K., would help to soothe public opinion abroad, as well as among Kurds and their supporters at home. But it was a half measure, and not helpful to the peace process.

Over the years, even as it has negotiated with Ocalan and courted the Kurdish vote, the A.K.P. has continued with some forms of repression. In the absence of armed fighting, the conflict plays out at organized protests, in parliament, and in the courts—all arenas where the Turkish government retains far more authority than the Kurdish minority. This authority comes, in large part, from the designation of the P.K.K. as a terrorist organization, and the tendency on the part of the government to conflate all aspects of Kurdish life with the P.K.K. (despite the fact that many Kurds reject the P.K.K.’s rigid hierarchy and its willingness to resort to violence). Under the guise of fighting terrorism, the A.K.P. has frequently cracked down on Kurdish institutions, protesters, and political leaders. A mass court case, opened in 2007 against a group called the Union of Communities in Kurdistan (K.C.K.), which the government considers the urban arm of the P.K.K., has led to the detention of thousands of Kurdish and Turkish activists, journalists, academics, and politicians.

So when Erdoğan called the P.K.K. terrorists as it fought in Kobani, it was more than political maneuvering; it was foreshadowing. Soon after the Kobani protests, the Turkish parliament proposed a bill that expands the powers of the Turkish police to allow it to arrest protesters suspected of carrying stones or Molotov cocktails, or who cover their faces. It increases the amount of time those protesters can be detained, and the severity of the sentence if they are convicted. These measures inspire little outrage in the foreign media, but their impact on Turkey’s Kurds could be immense.

“People believe that when the question is Kurds, Erdoğan doesn’t care about anything,” Ramazan Tunç, a Diyarbakır-based economist, told me. Tunç spent the past two years trying to establish a university in Diyarbakır that would have Kurdish as one of three primary languages, a project that would have been impossible before 1991, during the post-coup years when any language other than Turkish was banned. “In Kurdistan, in two days, forty-six people have lost their lives,” Tunç said, referring to the violent protests over Kobani. “Are we going back to the nineties?”

Tunç professed solidarity with Kurds in Kobani, but he was not alone in his concern about the fallout from Kobani at home. In late October, three Turkish soldiers were killed in the southeast, and many media reports assumed that the gunmen were members of the P.K.K. On Tuesday morning, a politician with the pro-Kurdish People’s Democratic Party (H.D.P.) was stabbed in Ankara, outside party headquarters. The next day, youth associated with the P.K.K. reportedly set up barricades around a Kurdish border town and declared its autonomy. Reports that the government was secretly planning to shut down the H.D.P. were quickly refuted by officials, but both sides engaged in a fiery exchange of words. Prime Minister Ahmet Davutoğlu accused the H.D.P. of “thuggery,” while Kurdish officials said that the attacks were part of a “lynching campaign.” A mainstream newspaper launched a splashy new graphic that asked if terrorism was returning to Turkey.

Perhaps prompted by the pile-up of events, the International Crisis Group published a report on

Thursday that aimed to remind both sides of the importance of the ceasefire. The group has long stressed peace between Turks and Kurds, but this time it offered a graver message: Turkey's war with the Kurds had crossed borders, and they were no longer each other's worst enemies. "Without first achieving peace at home," Hugh Pope, the deputy director of the Europe and Central Asia program, wrote, "both will remain highly vulnerable to what is in fact their common enemy, the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria."

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<http://theconversation.com/turkey-has-its-own-good-reasons-for-not-intervening-in-kobane-33896>

Turkey has its own good reasons for not intervening in Kobane

By Tristan Dunning, Honorary Research Fellow in the School of History, Philosophy, Religion and Classics at the University of Queensland

As the Kurdish town of Kobane continues to defy Islamic State (IS) forces, many pundits have condemned Turkey's unwillingness to help the People's Protection Units (YPG) keep the forces of "evil" at bay.

In a dichotomy characteristic of mainstream reporting on the Middle East, the Kurds, one of the region's perennial victims, have largely been cast as the "good guys". The YPG and PKK (Kurdistan Workers' Party) lived up to that image by helping to rescue Yazidis trapped on Mount Sinjar.

Turkey, in possession of NATO's second-largest army, has been thrown in with the "bad guys". This perception was heightened when protests in Kurdish majority areas of Turkey against government inaction resulted in more than 40 deaths. But is this "bad guy" label a fair representation of Turkey's reluctance to intervene in Kobane?

The Turkish government has valid reasons not to become embroiled in the defence of Kobane against IS. It would be a breach of Syrian sovereignty and international law.

Also, the YPG is the military wing of the Democratic Union Party (PYD), the predominant faction of three non-contiguous self-declared Kurdish autonomous regions of Rojava (Western/Syrian Kurdistan), which is linked to the PKK. This is a movement that waged a decades-long guerrilla war, at a cost of more than 40,000 lives, in pursuit of independent state at the expense of Turkish territorial integrity.

The PKK is now more committed to Kurdish self-determination than separatism. A ceasefire has been in effect since March 2013. The PKK, and the PYD by association, is still listed as a proscribed terrorist organisation by Turkey and much of the west, including Australia and the US.

Territorial integrity comes first for Turkey

Turkish sovereignty, and in particular territorial integrity, has been an extremely prickly subject since the First World War. This didn't just lead to the dismantling of the Ottoman Empire – which contributed to many of the problems in the region today – but also the Allied invasion of Turkish Anatolia. A Kurdish state was proposed, which would have included vast tracts of land ceded from what is today recognised as Turkey.

In effect, the war didn't finish for Turkey until 1923. Turkey's borders today are the result of nationalist resistance led by Mustafa Kemal Atatürk. Merely referring to "Kurdistan" can trigger an angry response, as I experienced while travelling in Capadoccia in October 2013 when I mentioned working in Iraqi Kurdistan.

Turkey, in essence, is being asked to risk its soldiers to save a “terrorist” organisation that has been trying to dismember the Turkish state for decades. The government couldn’t sell this to the wider Turkish public even if it wanted to.

More to the point, it suits Turkey that IS and the YPG/PKK are slugging it out: not only are two of its primary enemies otherwise occupied, but they are weakening each other.

Kobane is not a strategic priority

If Kobane falls, it will be a blow to PKK prestige. The Turkish government is calculating that a PKK threat to end the peace process if Kobane falls is a bluff; the Kurds are too weak to fight both IS and Turkey at once.

Turks are not entirely unwilling to help. The country is hosting some 1.5 million refugees, including around 200,000 from the Kobane area. Given Australia’s reaction to asylum seekers, and the pitiful numbers taken in by Turkey’s NATO allies, it’s a bit rich to criticise Turkey as being unhelpful.

While the resistance in Kobane has been impressive and the political organisation of Rojava is regionally unique in terms of its inclusiveness of women and minorities, US Secretary of State John Kerry’s declaration that Kobane is not of strategic importance is apt.

Hard up on the Turkish border, Kobane is otherwise surrounded by IS forces. As high-ranking members of Turkey’s ruling AK Party note, the vast majority of those left in the town are fighters and others who have chosen to remain.

On what conditions might Turkey intervene?

Turkey has not ruled out intervening, but it has a list of conditions.

Turkey demands a renewed focus on toppling the Assad regime, which entails renewed training of the seemingly mythical “moderates” of the Free Syrian Army (FSA). Turkey points out that whatever happens in Kobane pales in comparison to the ongoing bloodshed in Syria. This three-and-a-half-year conflict has cost more than 200,000 lives.

Turkey also demands a buffer zone in Syrian territory to shield Turkey from IS retaliation should it intervene. The Turkish-Syrian border is some 900 kilometres long, porous and hard to defend. It is also unclear on what terms Turkey secured the release of consular staff held by IS after capturing the Iraqi city of Mosul in June.

It is true that Turkey has, until recently, done little to stop foreign fighters entering Syria to fight the Assad regime. Before the ascendancy of Islamist radicals, however, supporting anti-Assad rebels was the de facto policy of many regional states, the Obama administration and other western governments. It wasn’t until the Islamist monster created by the proverbial Dr Frankensteins of the region escaped that this policy began to shift.

Finally, Turkey demands that the PYD renounce its territorial ambitions. Unsurprisingly, the PYD refuses to do this in light of its strong position in the two other self-declared autonomous regions of Rojava. The PYD has been accused of collaborating with the Assad regime – the Syrian army withdrew from Kurdish areas without a fight, yet officials were subsequently on hand to assist with Yazidis rescued from Sinjar – and Turkey has no intention of allowing another PKK haven to be set up along its borders.

Kurds are not a united force

The PKK already operates from the Qandil mountains in Kurdish Regional Government (KRG) territory in Iraq. There is, however, no love lost between the dominant party of the KRG – the Kurdish Democratic Party – and the PKK as they vie for leadership of the wider Kurdish national movement.

The KRG has even, in the past, allowed the Turkish army into the autonomous region to conduct operations against the PKK. While travelling in the mountains near Turkey I was surprised to drive past a Turkish army base on Iraqi soil, before being shown a valley desolated by Turkish bombs years earlier.

The KRG has also refused to recognise the autonomous cantons of Rojava. The KRG says a ditch it has dug along the KRG-Syria border is to keep IS out, but Syrian Kurds see it as a "betrayal" with the purpose of keeping them out. In short, the KRG is often seen as a Turkish lackey and Kurdish political unity is a myth.

This explains why Turkey agreed to help transfer Iraqi Kurdish Peshmerga and FSA reinforcements in the defence of Kobane. Only 150 Peshmerga and 50 FSA fighters have been allowed to enter Kobane. Despite an ostensible unity agreement recently signed by the KRG and PYD, the latter sees a large, Turkish-assisted influx of these fighters as a means of weakening PYD, and by extension PKK, influence in Rojava. The PYD thus refused the much higher numbers originally touted.

Given all these factors, it's unsurprising that Turkey refuses to intervene with boots of the ground. Other US-aligned "coalition" members haven't volunteered to do much more than engage in what often appears to be an elaborate and exceptionally expensive way to destroy empty buildings.

The PYD-YPG resistance is testimony to their courage, but the western public's fleeting emotional investment in Kobane isn't going to flick a magic switch in the Turkish majority's collective consciousness after decades of separatist conflict.

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Kurds gain ground but not control in struggle for Kobani

Syrian Kurds backed by fighters from northern Iraq have gained ground towards breaking the siege of the Syrian border town of Kobani but are drawing heavy fire from Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant (ISIL) insurgents and have yet to win back control.

Iraqi Kurdish peshmerga, or "those who face death," arrived with armored vehicles and artillery more than a week ago to try to repulse a more than month-old siege that has tested a US-led coalition's ability to stop the insurgents.

Known in Arabic as Ayn al-Arab, the town is among a few areas in civil war-ridden Syria where the coalition can coordinate air strikes against ISIL with operations by an effective ground force.

The Britain-based Syrian Observatory for Human Rights said fierce overnight clashes between Kurdish and ISIL forces along Kobani's southern front, combined with heavy artillery fire by peshmerga, yield new gains for the Kurds.

The Observatory quoted sources around Kobani as saying the radical insurgents had been surprised by the resilience of the Kurdish forces and that the battle for the town had killed hundreds of ISIL combatants.

Kurdish forces have retaken some villages around Kobani but a Reuters correspondent on the Turkish side of the border said the front lines in the town itself appeared little changed, with the insurgents still controlling its eastern part.

Mortar bombs launched from ISIL positions hit the center of town on Tuesday and there were exchanges of machinegun fire as jets flew overhead. The Observatory said coalition planes launched three air strikes south of Kobani overnight.

Idris Nassan, a local official in Kobani, estimated that ISIL now controlled less than 20 percent of the town and that heavy artillery salvos by peshmerga had helped the Kurds to advance to the south and east.

Peshmerga fighters, positioned on a hill on the western side of the town, launched rockets at a building where ISIL had raised its black flag, according to a Reuters witness.

A video on YouTube distributed by ISIL supporters showed fighters purportedly in Syria's northern province of Raqqa promising to reinforce Kobani.

"God's servants have prepared the explosives and bombs ... We are coming with the sword and the Koran ... We tell our brothers in (Kobani) that we're coming to support you," one of the insurgents said in the video.
